

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 15 & 16

CHAPTER 15: FATHER MOORE: FIRST CONTACT

Flashback. December 1976.

Father Richard Moore did not like hospitals.

They reminded him of purgatory. Waiting rooms filled with people clutching rosaries and magazines, hoping for a reprieve, fearing the judgment of the man in the white coat.

He walked down the corridor of the psychiatric ward. The linoleum was worn down to the black backing in the center, a path eroded by fifty years of gurneys and pacing families.

The air smelled of ammonia, floor wax, and the distinct, metallic tang of Thorazine.

He stopped at the nurses' station.

"I'm here to see Emily Rose," he said.

The nurse, a woman with a face like a dried apple, looked up over her reading glasses.

"Family?"

"Parish priest. Richard Moore."

She looked at his collar. It was frayed at the edge.

"She's in Room 304. But she's sedated. Dr. Vogel's orders."

"I just want to pray with her."

"Pray quietly," the nurse said. "She had a bad night. Screaming about fire."

Moore walked to Room 304.

The door was heavy, solid wood with a small, reinforced glass window.

He looked through the glass.

The room was dim. The blinds were drawn, slicing the afternoon light into thin grey bars.

Emily lay in the bed.

She looked... diminished.

He had known Emily since she was a child. He had given her First Communion. He had seen her grow from a shy girl in pigtails to a bright, hopeful student.

The girl in the bed looked like a husk.

Her skin was translucent, blue veins mapping the geography of her suffering. Her hair was matted. Her wrists were restrained.

Leather straps padded with wool.

Moore felt a surge of anger. *She is not a criminal.*

He pushed the door open. It hissed on hydraulic hinges.

He stepped inside.

The air in the room was colder than the hallway. Much colder.

He could see his breath.

"Emily?"

She didn't move. Her eyes were closed. Her chest rose and fell in a shallow, drugged rhythm.

Moore pulled a chair to the bedside. The metal legs scraped against the floor. *Screeeeee.*

He sat down.

He took his stole from his pocket—a strip of purple silk—and kissed the cross embroidered on it. He placed it around his neck.

"In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit."

He reached out to touch her hand.

Her skin was ice.

Not the cold of a corpse. The cold of a stone that has been in a deep cave for a thousand years.

"Father?"

Her voice was a whisper. Dry leaves skittering on pavement.

Moore leaned in. "I'm here, Emily. It's Father Moore."

She opened her eyes.

Her pupils were blown wide, swallowing the iris. Black holes.

"They won't let me go," she whispered.

"The doctors? They want to help you."

"Not the doctors," she said. "The others."

Moore felt a chill at the base of his spine.

"What others, Emily?"

"The ones in the wall. The ones in the wire."

She looked at the IV drip. The clear fluid counting down the seconds of her life. *Drip. Drip.*

"They travel in the medicine," she said. "They ride the needle."

Moore frowned. "That's the sickness talking, Emily. The medicine stops the seizures."

"The medicine stops the *body*," she said. Her voice was getting stronger. Deeper. "It locks the door. But it locks *me* in with *them*."

She grabbed his hand. Her grip was shocking. Iron-hard.

"You have to get me out."

"I can't, Emily. You're sick."

"I'm not sick!"

She sat up, straining against the straps. The leather groaned.

"Look at me, Father! Look!"

She stared at him.

And for a second...

Her face changed.

It wasn't a physical change. Her nose didn't grow; her teeth didn't sharpen.

It was a shift in *presence*.

The girl he knew retreated. Something else stepped forward. Something old. Something arrogant.

It smiled.

It wasn't Emily's smile. It was a smile that mocked the very idea of smiling.

"Hello, Priest," the voice said.

It came from her throat, but it didn't sound like her vocal cords. It sounded like two stones grinding together.

Moore pulled his hand back. "Emily?"

"Emily is away," the voice said. *"She is in the corner. Crying."*

"Who are you?" Moore whispered.

The thing laughed. A dry, hacking sound.

"I am the one who dwells."

"Name yourself."

"Names are power, Priest. You have no power here. This is a house of science. A house of doubt. We thrive in doubt."

The lights in the room flickered.

Buzz-click.

The temperature dropped another ten degrees. The water in the pitcher on the nightstand began to ripple.

Moore stood up. He grabbed his rosary.

"Hail Mary, full of grace..."

"She can't hear you!" the thing shrieked. *"The drugs block the signal! We are the static!"*

Emily convulsed. Her back arched off the bed. The bed frame rattled. *Clang-clang-clang.*

"Nurse!" Moore yelled.

The door burst open.

The nurse with the apple face rushed in. Two orderlies behind her.

"Get out!" she yelled at Moore.

"She's hurting!"

"She's seizing! Get out!"

The orderlies grabbed Moore. They shoved him toward the door.

"I can help her!" Moore shouted.

"You're making it worse!"

They pushed him into the hallway. The door slammed shut.

Moore stood there, breathing hard.

He looked at his hands. They were shaking.

He looked at the door.

From inside, he heard a sound.

Not a scream.

A laugh.

A low, satisfied laugh.

Moore reached into his pocket. He took out a small notebook. A black moleskine.

He opened it.

His hands were trembling so hard he could barely write.

Date: Dec 14.

Subject: Emily Rose.

Observation: The entity is aware. It is intelligent. It claims the medication acts as a barrier to grace.

Conclusion:

He hesitated. The pen hovered over the paper.

If he wrote it, it was real. If he wrote it, he was crossing a line.

He looked at the door again. He remembered the cold. He remembered the eyes.

He wrote:

Conclusion: Medicine has failed. We must move to spiritual warfare.

He closed the book.

He put it in his pocket.

It felt heavy. Like a stone. Or a weapon.

CHAPTER 16: EXHIBIT B: THE PRESCRIPTION

[INTERSTITIAL DOCUMENT: DEFENSE EXHIBIT 14]

****DOCUMENT:**** Prescription Pad (Dr. Mueller, General Practitioner / Dr. Vogel, Neurologist).

****DATES:**** October 1976 - January 1977.

The document was projected onto the screen in the courtroom. It was a mosaic of slips of paper, taped together, creating a timeline of chemistry.

Erin Bruner stood next to the screen. She held a laser pointer. The red dot was steady.

"This," she said to the jury, "is a map."

She pointed to the first slip.

****DATE:**** Oct 14, 1976.

****RX:**** *Gambrolic (Carbamazepine).*

****DOSE:**** *200mg b.i.d. (Twice daily).*

****NOTES:**** *Initial diagnosis: TLE. Patient reports anxiety.*

"This is where it started," Erin said. "A standard dose. Therapeutic. Safe."

She moved the dot down.

****DATE:**** Nov 01, 1976.

****RX:**** *Gambrolic.*

****DOSE:**** *400mg b.i.d.*

****NOTES:**** *Patient reports breakthrough seizures. Visual hallucinations persisting. Increase dosage.*

"Two weeks later," Erin said. "Doubled the dose. Why? Because the 'cure' wasn't working. The 'sickness' was fighting back."

She moved the dot again.

****DATE:**** Nov 15, 1976.

****RX:**** *Gambrolic.*

****DOSE:**** *600mg b.i.d.*

****ADDITIONAL RX:**** *Diazepam (Valium) 10mg PRN (As needed for panic).*

****NOTES:**** *Patient agitated. Combativeness. Claims drugs are 'poison'.*

"Now we have a cocktail," Erin said. "We have an anticonvulsant to stop the brain from firing, and a sedative to stop the patient from caring."

She looked at Juror 11 (The Nurse). The nurse was frowning. She knew what that much Gambrolic did to a liver. She knew what it did to a mind.

Erin moved the dot to the final slip.

****DATE:**** Dec 20, 1976.

****RX:**** *Haldol (Haloperidol).*

****DOSE:**** *5mg.*

****NOTES:**** * psychotic break. Patient claims to be 'Legion'. Sedation required.*

"Haldol," Erin whispered. "An antipsychotic. A chemical sledgehammer."

She turned to the jury.

"Look at the timeline. October to December. Two months."

She pointed to the margin of the exhibit.

There were handwritten notes. Dr. Vogel's handwriting. Small, cramped.

Patient resistance increasing.

Family interference?

Priest involved.

Erin highlighted the last note.

Priest involved.

"Dr. Vogel saw Father Moore as a variable," Erin said. "A complication. An interference."

She turned off the laser pointer.

"But look at the dosages. 200. 400. 600. Haldol."

She walked to the defense table.

"They weren't treating a disease. They were trying to drown a fire. And every time they poured more water on it... the fire got hotter."

She picked up the photo of Emily—the one from the hospital, where she looked grey and lost.

"Dr. Vogel calls this 'titration'. He calls it 'standard of care'."

She looked at Father Moore.

"Father Moore called it what it was."

She dropped the photo on the table.

"Suffocation."

****[ERIN'S PRIVATE NOTEBOOK - MARGIN NOTE]****

The jury looks bored by the chemistry. Make it visceral.

Metaphor: The drug isn't a wall. It's a dam. And the river is rising.

If the dam breaks... everything drowns.

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